SEX, LIES AND TCS

Multiple FIRs and an expanding police dragnet point to a possible pattern of abuse, coercion and systemic lapses at the company's Nashik BPO

By **ADITI PAI** *in Nashik* / *Illustrations by* **NILANJAN DAS / AI**

From the outside, the office of the Tata Consultancy Services BPO in Ashoka Business Enclave on Wadala Road looks like any other IT company office—young employees streaming in and out of the building, their bags piled up on a rack at the entrance at the beginning of the day and, at night, young women hurrying home on their scooties or in waiting autorickshaws. A short distance away is Wadalagaon, a congested locality with pockets of slums and old residential settlements with a sizeable Muslim population. Many of its youth, some armed with a bachelor's degree in computer applications, find employment in Nashik's IT firms. The companies, including TCS, in turn, prefer local youth so they can work night shifts without having to travel too far.

Yet no one had a whiff of the alleged scandal at the TCS BPO on the third floor, employing around 150 staffers, despite it being in the middle of a bustling commercial complex on a busy road, with Ashoka Hospital next door and housing several IT and BPO firms. Until, as a TCS employee reveals, a young woman sent a message to a social activist in Nashik late one March night, saying, "Dada, I need to meet you... there is a problem." He reached her apartment, a few kilometres away, not knowing what to expect. It was past 2.30 am, when the woman began narrating a harrowing tale of alleged verbal and sexual abuse at the workplace. Being married and not wanting her family to find out, she was unwilling to file an FIR. Another colleague, Vaishnavi (*name changed*), she said, did file a written complaint with the police but later withdrew it, fearing repercussions.

Sensing that something was amiss, Nashik police commissioner Sandeep Karnik swung into action, forming a team of women officers to infiltrate the organisation. They quietly mapped the routines and behaviour of the accused, studied CCTV footage, identified possible victims and gently counselled them to speak up and file formal complaints. Going by their accounts, an alleged web of deceit was playing out in the BPO, with sexual violence, blackmail, coercion and attempts at religious conversion. This seemed to have been going on for three years, it is alleged, with complaints either dismissed or ignored.



"The accused were in important positions, so they misused their authority and position to sexually and religiously harass co-workers"

SANDEEP KARNIK
Police Commissioner, Nashik

Nine FIRs, eight by women, one by a man, have been filed so far, though, according to the social activist, there may be up to 60 complaints. Six men—Danish Sheikh, 39; Tausif Attar, Raza Memon, Shahrukh Qureshi and Shafi Sheikh, all 35; Asif Ansari, 22—and two women—Ashwini Chainani, 51, assistant general manager, operations, and Nida Khan, 25, who TCS says was a "process associate"—have been charged under various sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita—including sexual harassment, stalking, hurting religious sentiments—as well as the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act. Seven of the accused have been arrested, while Nida is on the run (see *The Accused*).

The allegations and complaints from TCS's Nashik unit have clearly shaken the Tata Group. In a press release, Tata Sons chairman N. Chandrasekaran described it as "gravely concerning and anguishing", adding that "the incident is being treated with the utmost seriousness. The Tata Group maintains a zero-tolerance policy towards any form of coercion or misconduct by its employees. A thorough